

Teacher Manual: MJ World History, Dawn of Civilization to Roman Empire

Facilitator copy. Contains answer guides, rubrics, grading thresholds, and sensitive-content scripts.

Do not publish this document to students. This document is complete: eighteen weekly modules (Weeks 1–18), two Quarterly MC Exams, the recurring weekly assessment set (Reading Quiz, Critical Questions, Primary Source Exercise, two VR Activities, and, on six weeks each, a graded VR Activity or a Discussion), and the full standards benchmark index (Section 9). Built across two authoring sessions (2026-08-03 and 2026-08-04), per the build's own batch-by-quarter plan. Keep it in your teacher files and re-render it if the course is revised.

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How to use this manual

This is the facilitator guide for MJ World History: Dawn of Civilization to Roman Empire. It assumes you already have access to the built Canvas course (course 104) and its linked GitHub-hosted lesson pages. Read Sections 1, 2, and 4 before your first week; keep Sections 5, 6, and 7 open while you grade; use Section 10 to plan your pacing and see what each week actually covers; read Section 14 before the weeks it flags. Everything here is drawn from the course as it actually exists and was verified directly against the live Canvas course, not assumed from build notes. Anything that depends on your school's current Canvas configuration is marked **[VERIFY]**.

How this course works: typical lesson, typical module, major assessments

A typical lesson page. Every one of this course's 36 lessons and 36 primary-source pages is a standalone, GitHub-hosted HTML document embedded into its paired Canvas page by `<iframe>`, never merely linked. Every page carries real hover-and-audio glossing (not just a static definition) on every bolded term: a Glossary of Subject Vocabulary box at the top of the lesson where a term first appears (and again on the immediately following lesson only, never longer than that window), and a separate Foreign Language Vocabulary box placed inline near the first use of any non-English term or historical figure's name, both wired to the browser's built-in text-to-speech for pronunciation. Every lesson also carries a Main Map with a Geographical Glossary, Historical Figure call-out boxes for every named figure, and Technology, Peoples, Cities, and Battle call-out boxes wherever the week's content calls for one. **No embedded interactive widget (drag-and-drop, matcher, tracer) is built anywhere in this course as of this manual's writing.** Two widget ideas were identified at the planning stage (a domestication-matching activity for Week 1, a cuneiform-tracing activity for Week 2) but both remain design notes only, never implemented. This is a real, confirmed gap, not an oversight to paper over; see Section 12.

The graded touchpoints are never on the lesson page itself. They are the separate Canvas items that follow it in the module: the Reading Quiz, the linked Primary Sources, the Critical Questions, the Primary Source Exercise, and (on six weeks only) a Discussion or a graded VR Activity.

A typical module. One numbered module fills one week, exactly. There is no multi-week module anywhere in this course. Every module follows the identical internal shape, with two variations noted below:

Segment	What the student does	Graded?	Tier
Module Intro Wrapper (every module)	Answers the week's essential question cold; names something they're curious about; opts in/out of optional group work	Completion (survey)	4

Lesson 1	Reads the lesson page (Reading Topic, first half)	No	N/A
Reading Quiz 1	Auto-graded multiple-choice inference questions on Lesson 1	Auto	1
Primary Source 1	Reads the week's first assigned primary source	No	N/A
Critical Questions	Two open-ended reasoned answers, one per excerpt, on Primary Source 1	Teacher-graded	3
Lesson 2 + Primary Source 2	Second half of the week's topic and its source	No	N/A
Primary Source Exercise	Two open-ended reasoned answers on Primary Source 2	Teacher-graded	3
Discussion (Weeks 2, 4, 9, 11, 13, 16 only)	Defends a specific claim from the week's Discussion Topic, then responds to a classmate	Teacher-graded (light)	2
Two VR Activities (every week)	One in-headset session tied to the week's content; both supplemental unless the week is graded (see row below)	Completion (unpublished by default)	4
One VR Activity (Weeks 6, 7, 8, 12, 15, 18 only)	Replaces one of the two above as the week's required, graded, rubric-scored deliverable	Teacher-graded	3
Module Outro Wrapper (every module)	Revisits the essential question; rates confidence; names what's still unclear; reflects on which virtue the week's history most called for	Completion (survey)	4

Major assessments. Beyond the recurring weekly set, the course carries the Quarter 1 Exam (27 multiple-choice questions, placed between Week 9 and Week 10), the Quarter 2 Exam (27 questions, placed at the close of Week 18), and the optional, ungraded Course Review closing the semester (a Tier 1 quiz, a Tier 2 discussion, and a Tier 3 comparative essay, all marked `omit_from_final_grade`, see Section 12). Both exams sit in their own dedicated "Quarterly Exams" assignment group, not inside Tier 1 or Tier 3; see Sections 4 and 7 for why.

Module map (all 18 weeks).

Wk	Topic	Featured assignment
1	The Neolithic Revolution: Farming Begins Across the Ancient World	Reading Quiz
2	Sumer and the Rise of the First Cities	Reading Quiz

3	Sargon and the World's First Empire: The Akkadians	Primary Source Report
4	Hammurabi and Old Babylon: Law and Kingship in Mesopotamia	Primary Source Report
5	The Gift of the Nile: Predynastic Egypt and the Old Kingdom	Reading Quiz
6	Pharaohs and Empire: Middle and New Kingdom Egypt	VR Activity (graded)
7	Beyond Mesopotamia and Egypt: The Indus Valley and Shang China	VR Activity (graded)
8	Palaces and Powers: Minoan Crete, Mycenaean Greece, and the Hittite Empire	VR Activity (graded); <i>Quarter 1 Exam follows Week 9</i>
9	The Bronze Age Collapse: Ancient Near East in Crisis	Primary Source Report
10	Twilight of the Pharaohs: Egypt's Third Intermediate Period and the Saite Revival	Reading Quiz
11	Assyria Fills the Vacuum: The Rise of the Neo-Assyrian Empire	Primary Source Report
12	Nineveh and Ashurbanipal: The Assyrian Empire at Its Height and Its Fall	VR Activity (graded)
13	Nebuchadnezzar's Babylon: The Neo-Babylonian Empire and the Fall of Jerusalem	Primary Source Report
14	The Medes: Six Centuries in the Shadows of the Zagros Mountains	Reading Quiz
15	Phoenicia in the Mediterranean: Carthage Faces Rome	VR Activity (graded)
16	The Greek Dark Ages: Homer and a New Beginning for Greece	Reading Quiz
17	Cyrus the Great: Mesopotamia Under Persian Rule	Primary Source Report
18	Cambyses II Conquers Egypt: Persian Empire Unites the Ancient World	VR Activity (graded); <i>Quarter 2 Exam and the optional Course Review follow</i>

"Featured assignment" names the Course Map's headline item for standards-tracking purposes only. It does not replace the fixed Mon–Thu rhythm above, which runs identically every week.

2Ungraded interactives & the intro/outro wrappers

Two things new facilitators most often misread:

- **The hover/audio glossary tooltips cost you nothing.** Every glossed term on every one of the 72 GitHub-hosted pages (36 lessons, 36 primary sources) gives students an immediate definition and pronunciation and never produces a submission. A student who skips them will show it indirectly, a weaker Reading Quiz score, a thinner Critical Questions answer, not as a missing grade. Do not build a gradebook column for them.
- **The wrappers are Canvas Quizzes in survey mode, not pages.** That is what makes the data sortable across your roster.

Wrapper	Q #	Type	What it captures
Intro (every module)	1	Essay	The week's essential question, answered cold, before that week's lessons
	2	Essay	One thing the student is curious to find out this week
	3	Multiple choice	Opt-in for optional group discussion or work this module (Yes / No preference / No, independent)
Outro (every module)	1	Essay	The same essential question, revisited: has the student's answer changed, and why
	2	Multiple choice	Four-point confidence rating
	3	Essay	Free response: what idea, term, or question still feels unclear
	4	Essay	Which virtue (for example: curiosity, patience, honesty, prudence) the week's history most called for, and why

The single highest-leverage move in the course. Spend 15–20 minutes reading each module's Outro Wrapper responses as a set. Sort for low-confidence clusters and repeated "still unclear" concepts. Then act: post one targeted announcement addressing the top confusion, and message the two or three students whose confidence dropped. This finds struggling students before a grade would.

3 VR in this course

Every module carries two solo VR activities, thirty-six across the year, no exceptions. On six weeks (6, 7, 8, 12, 15, 18) one of the two is the week's required, graded, rubric-scored deliverable (20 points, the standard four-criterion Tier 3 rubric, see Section 5); the paired activity that same week, and both activities on the other twelve weeks, are supplemental and currently unpublished at zero points, live in Tier 4 for a teacher to assign at their own discretion. This course has no ENGAGE-specific vocabulary anywhere: this school no longer uses ENGAGE, so every VR assignment is written in platform-neutral language, describing the activity (trace, sculpt, assemble, explore, compare) rather than a specific vendor's features. Do not add ENGAGE, IFX, Sessions, or Locations terminology to any VR text in this course; that language is deliberately absent by design, not an omission.

Every VR assignment states a title, what the student is doing, what they'll need, how to join, numbered steps, what to submit, and an honest time estimate. The six graded activities additionally carry the Section 5 rubric.

4 Grading categories & Canvas gradebook setup

The course runs five weighted assignment groups, confirmed live via a fresh, non-cached API read. Weights are percentage-based; confirm they imported intact for your section.

Group id	Group	Weight	What's in it	Items
272	Tier 1: Reading Quizzes	21%	Both weekly Reading Quizzes (36) plus the optional Course Review's Tier 1 quiz	37
293	Tier 2: Weekly Discussions and Course Reflection	15%	The six weekly Discussions (Weeks 2, 4, 9, 11, 13, 16) plus the optional Course Review's Tier 2 discussion	7
294	Tier 3: Deep Feedback (VR Assessments, Critical Questions, Primary Source Exercises)	34%	All 36 weekly Critical Questions/Primary Source Exercises, the 6 required VR Activities, the Appendices Olmec Primary Source Exercise, and the optional Course Review's Tier 3 essay	44
295	Tier 4: Module Check-Ins (Ungraded)	0%	The 30 supplemental, currently unpublished VR Activities; the module intro/outro wrapper surveys carry no points and no assignment-group	30 (plus wrappers)

membership at all

427	Quarterly Exams	30%	The Quarter 1 Exam and Quarter 2 Exam only	2
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Total	100%	90 graded items, plus 30 unpublished and the wrapper surveys		
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Common mix-up worth flagging: Critical Questions and Primary Source Exercises read like light-touch Tier 2 discussion work at a glance, since they are two open-ended written-response questions, not a formal essay. They are deliberately placed in **Tier 3** (group 294) instead, because a skill-alignment review found them to be genuine reasoning-quality-graded work with no single right answer, the profile Optima's own tiering rubric defines as Tier 3, not Tier 2. Check the group column, not the item's apparent weight or length, before assuming a tier.

1. Gradebook > Settings > Weight final grade based on assignment groups. Confirm the five groups above and their weights (21 / 15 / 34 / 0 / 30).
2. Confirm each item sits in the right group: Reading Quizzes → Tier 1. Weekly Discussions → Tier 2. Critical Questions, Primary Source Exercises, and the 6 graded VR Activities → Tier 3. The two Quarterly Exams → their own dedicated group, not Tier 1 despite being auto-graded multiple choice.
3. Confirm both wrappers on every module are survey/completion (zero points, no assignment-group), so they gather data without distorting grades.
4. If you publish any of the 30 supplemental VR activities, they will need a points value and a Tier assigned before they count toward a grade; as delivered they are ungraded scaffolding only.

Section

5 Rubrics & answer guides for teacher-graded items

The course carries 44 Canvas rubrics, one per Tier 3 item, all built on the same four-criterion base, confirmed live via a fresh API read of a representative sample (a Critical Questions rubric, a VR Activity rubric, and the cumulative-final essay rubric).

Criterion	Critical Questions / Primary Source Exercise (37 rubrics)	VR Activity (6 rubrics)	Course Review Tier 3 Essay (1 rubric)
Understanding of the material	2.5 pts	5 pts	5 pts
Quality of reasoning	2.5 pts	5 pts	5 pts

Clarity and precision of expression	2.5 pts	5 pts	5 pts
Intellectual honesty (naming the limits of your own understanding)	2.5 pts	5 pts	5 pts
Total	10	20	20

Every Critical Questions and Primary Source Exercise carries exactly two open-ended questions, one per quoted excerpt, drawn from a rotating menu of reasoning types (counterfactual, historical causation, conceptual) and never labeled by category in student-facing text.

Answer guides: teacher only, never shown to students. Full credit on a *conceptual* question means the student names an idea genuinely at work in the source that the source itself never states outright. This course's own worked example is Week 17: given Herodotus's account of Solon's warning to Croesus ("count no man happy until you have seen how his life ends"), a full-credit answer identifies the underlying idea as a claim about the instability of worldly fortune, not merely fame or wealth, and connects it forward to Croesus's actual downfall at Cyrus's hands. A partial-credit answer restates that Croesus was proud or that his wealth did not save him, without naming the more general claim Solon is making about human fortune. Full credit on a *counterfactual* question requires an argument, not just a guess: a student weighing whether Cyrus's tolerance bound the Persian Empire together more effectively than Assyria's terror (Weeks 11–12 versus Week 17) earns full credit by citing specific evidence on both sides, not simply by picking a side. Whichever conclusion the student reaches, judge the reasoning, not the verdict.

Section

6 Assessment & activity catalog: how to run and grade each type

Type	Scoring	Recommended move
Reading Quiz (Tier 1)	Auto-graded MC	Leave to auto-grade. Scan item analysis for a question the whole cohort missed, that's your next announcement, not a regrade.
Critical Questions (Tier 3)	Teacher-graded, two open-ended questions, one per excerpt	Grade in a batch per module. Lead feedback with what the student did well before naming the next step. Attach rubric 396-series (see Section 5).
Primary Source Exercise (Tier 3)	Teacher-graded, two open-ended questions	Same batch pass as Critical Questions; the same 10-point rubric applies.
Discussion (Tier 2, Weeks 2, 4, 9, 11, 13, 16)	Teacher-graded, light	Score on a simple substantive/thin/missing scale; drop

only)		2–3 public comments per cycle modeling good thinking.
VR Activity, graded (Tier 3, Weeks 6, 7, 8, 12, 15, 18)	Teacher-graded, 20-point rubric	The one deep-feedback item those six weeks add on top of the fixed weekly set; budget real per-student time.
VR Activity, supplemental (Tier 4, unpublished by default)	Not graded as delivered	Publish and assign points only if you want to require it; otherwise leave as teacher's-discretion enrichment.
Quarterly MC Exam	Auto-graded MC, 27 items, non-cumulative	Leave to auto-grade. Review the item analysis to spot a systemic gap before moving into the next quarter.
Module Intro/Outro Wrapper (no tier, 0 points)	Survey/completion	Do not score for correctness. Read the outro as a set (Section 2).
Course Review, three parts (optional, omit from final grade)	Points assigned but excluded from the grade calculation	Grade normally if a student submits, for feedback's sake; it will not move their grade either way.

Section

Quarterly exams

Two Quarterly MC Exams, Canvas Quizzes 2309 (Quarter 1, Weeks 1–9) and 2310 (Quarter 2, Weeks 10–18), backed by assignments 7106 and 7107, each carry 27 multiple-choice questions worth 27 points and are non-cumulative (each covers only its own quarter). Both live in their own dedicated "Quarterly Exams" assignment group (id 427), weighted at a flat 30% of the course grade.

This is a deliberate, documented exception to `optima-mj-social-studies`' general instruction to fold quarterly exams into whichever existing group already holds quarter-culminating milestone work, rather than adding a new top-level category. The course lead made this choice because folding two 27-point exams into the existing Tier 1 or Tier 3 groups could not cleanly produce a real 30% outcome without either badly inflating the exams' own point values relative to everything else in that group, or leaving "around 30%" as an unreliable approximation. A dedicated group hits the target exactly, at the cost of a fifth top-level category. See Section 12.

Neither exam needs an EOC-standards emphasis; Grade 6 World History has no CPALMS End-of-Course exam at this grade band, so both are built for comprehensive coverage of that quarter's content only.

Section

8 Teacher workflow & workload map

A normal week, in order: triage outro-wrapper analytics at module boundaries → batch-grade the week's Critical Questions and Primary Source Exercise → on Weeks 2, 4, 9, 11, 13, and 16, score the Discussion and drop 2–3 public comments → on Weeks 6, 7, 8, 12, 15, and 18, grade the required VR Activity against its rubric → post the weekly announcement → answer messages. Tier 1 auto-grades at near zero teacher hours; the Quarterly Exams also auto-grade at near zero hours, twice a year.

The real Tier 3 load is well above the skill's generic default, and it is a structural, accepted cost, not a build error. optima-canvas-assignments recommends Tier 3 (deep, teacher-graded feedback) sit at roughly 10–15% of graded items. This course's Tier 3 group holds 44 of the course's 90 graded items, roughly 49%, because every week carries two teacher-graded written-response touchpoints (a Critical Questions set and a Primary Source Exercise) rather than one, on top of the six graded VR Activities and the Appendices Olmec exercise. This was reviewed and explicitly accepted by the course lead rather than rebalanced; see Section 12.

Tier / group	Item count	What it is	Teacher time
Tier 1 (272)	37	36 Reading Quizzes + the Course Review's Tier 1 quiz	Near zero, auto-graded
Tier 2 (293)	7	6 weekly Discussions + the Course Review's Tier 2 discussion	Light, batch-scored
Tier 3 (294)	44	36 Critical Questions/Primary Source Exercises + 6 VR Activities + the Olmec PSE + the Course Review's Tier 3 essay	The real weekly load, two written touchpoints every module
Tier 4 (295)	30 unpublished	Supplemental VR Activities, teacher's discretion to publish	None as delivered
Quarterly Exams (427)	2	27-question MC exams, once per quarter	Near zero, auto-graded

Where the load concentrates. Every week carries an identical Critical Questions + Primary Source Exercise pair, so the base grading load is flat across all eighteen weeks. The six VR-Activity weeks (6, 7, 8, 12, 15, 18) add one further rubric-scored item each; the six Discussion weeks (2, 4, 9, 11, 13, 16) add a lighter, batch-scored item each. No single week carries both a graded VR Activity and a Discussion.

9Standards coverage: the full benchmark index

This index satisfies optima-world-history Part II's requirement for "a comprehensive, indexed entry listing every standards benchmark for the course, showing which lessons and assessments... satisfy each one." It reformats 03_Build/plan.md Section 2's master standards-coverage table, cross-checked against every week's own week-overview.md "Standards addressed this week" note (not re-derived from the lessons themselves). optima-mj-social-studies Section I does not apply to this course; Grade 6 World History carries no Florida EOC, so there is no separate EOC index to build alongside this one.

82 total CPALMS benchmarks make up this course's full catalog (Civics 4, Economics 7, Geography 24, Historical/Civic Thinking 1, World History Era 1 through 4: $6 + 10 + 18 + 12 = 46$). Of those 82: **50 are satisfied, in full or in part, somewhere in this 18-week Fall build; 30 are Spring content by design** (chronologically out of scope this semester, not a gap); **1 (SS.6.W.2.10) has no Fall home and is satisfied by the Appendices' Olmec Primary Source Exercise instead; and 1 (SS.6.G.1.4) has no recorded coverage anywhere in plan.md or any week's own week-overview.md**, flagged below as unconfirmed rather than asserted. A benchmark marked "partial" in the tables below is genuinely and deliberately partial per CLAUDE.md; its remaining scope is Spring content, not an oversight.

Civics (SS.6.CG.1.x): 4 benchmarks.

Benchmark	Week(s) / Appendix	Note
SS.6.CG.1.1	Spring	Ancient Greek democratic concepts; Greece is not taught this Fall.
SS.6.CG.1.2	Spring	Roman influence on democratic government; Rome is not taught this Fall.
SS.6.CG.1.3	Weeks 4, 13 (partial)	Mesopotamian (Hammurabi's Code) and Mosaic (covenant/law) rule-of-law origin bridges; full Greek/Roman treatment is Spring.
SS.6.CG.1.4	Spring	Civic leadership and virtue via ancient Greek/Roman example; not taught this Fall.

Economics (SS.6.E): 7 benchmarks.

Benchmark	Week(s) / Appendix	Note
SS.6.E.1.1	Weeks 15, 17	Factors of economic growth (specialized labor, capital, entrepreneurship): Phoenician shipbuilding/dye production, Persian imperial trade.
SS.6.E.1.3	Weeks 1, 4	Agricultural surplus; scarcity and legal regulation of trade under Hammurabi's Code.
SS.6.E.2.1	Weeks 2, 8	The temple/palace economy; Sumerian redistribution; Bronze Age Aegean palace

economies.

SS.6.E.3.1	Week 15	Phoenician trade relationships.
SS.6.E.3.2	Weeks 3 (seed), 6, 15	Traded goods and barriers to trade, tracked across Akkad, Egypt, and Phoenicia.
SS.6.E.3.3	Week 10 (partial)	Egypt and Kush's traditional economy only; Greece and Rome are Spring content.
SS.6.E.3.4	Weeks 15, 17	Traded goods and trade relationships: Phoenician Mediterranean commerce; the unified Achaemenid trade zone.

Geography (SS.6.G): 24 benchmarks.

Benchmark	Week(s) / Appendix	Note
SS.6.G.1.1	Week 1	
SS.6.G.1.2	Week 18	Capstone map work, the Achaemenid Empire's full extent.
SS.6.G.1.3	Week 5	
SS.6.G.1.4	Unconfirmed	No week or appendix records coverage of this benchmark anywhere in plan.md Section 2 or any of the 18 week-overview.md files. Flagged rather than invented, per the course's no-fabricated-content rule. A future session should check this benchmark's own CPALMS clarification text against the built lessons directly, since this manual reformats existing planning records rather than re-deriving coverage from lesson content.
SS.6.G.1.5	Week 14	Map/distance work, Media's rise from the Zagros Mountains to the Halys River.
SS.6.G.1.6	Weeks 2, 5, 15, and Week 14	Weeks 2/5/15 per plan.md's table; Week 14 (Zagros Mountains) per Week 14's own week-overview.md, not listed against Week 14 in plan.md's table. Discrepancy logged, not silently resolved either way.
SS.6.G.1.7	Week 18	Capstone map work, alongside G.1.2.
SS.6.G.2.1	Weeks 1, 5, 8, 12, and Week 18	Weeks 1/5/8/12 per plan.md's table; Week 18 (Persian administrative reach) per Week 18's own week-overview.md, not listed against Week 18 in plan.md's table. Discrepancy logged, not silently resolved either way.
SS.6.G.2.2	Week 7	
SS.6.G.2.3	Weeks 1, 2, 5, 7	

SS.6.G.2.4	Weeks 8, 11	
SS.6.G.2.5	Weeks 6, 14, 15	
SS.6.G.2.6	Weeks 7, 10, 16, 17	
SS.6.G.2.7	Week 2	
SS.6.G.3.1	Week 1	
SS.6.G.3.2	Week 9	
SS.6.G.4.1	Week 14	
SS.6.G.4.2	Weeks 4, 13	
SS.6.G.4.3	Weeks 1, 7	
SS.6.G.4.4	Week 13	
SS.6.G.5.1	Week 6	
SS.6.G.5.2	Weeks 11, 15	
SS.6.G.5.3	Week 9	
SS.6.G.6.1	Week 1	Recurring "geographer's toolkit" callout in later weeks.

Historical/Civic Thinking (SS.6.HC): 1 benchmark.

Benchmark	Week(s) / Appendix	Note
SS.6.HC.1.1	Spring; no Fall appendix	Structurally requires Spartan communal life/helots/Agoge and Roman latifundia/Cura Annonae, none of which this Fall build reaches. Genuinely belongs to Spring, not a gap to patch.

World History, Era 1 (SS.6.W.1.x, historical-thinking skills): 6 benchmarks.

Benchmark	Week(s) / Appendix	Note
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SS.6.W.1.1	Cross-cutting, all 18 weeks	Era vocabulary and timeline conventions; no single anchor week named in p lan .md, by design (foundational skill used throughout).
SS.6.W.1.2	Week 1	
SS.6.W.1.3	Weeks 10, 12, 18, and Week 16	Weeks 10/12/18 per p lan .md's anchor list; Week 16 (oral tradition as a distinct kind of historical source) per Week 16's own week-overview .md, not listed against Week 16 in p lan .md's table. Discrepancy logged, not silently resolved either way. This also corrects the prior Section 9 stub's unconfirmed claim that Era 1 anchors fall "explicitly at Weeks 1 and 3"; neither p lan .md's table nor Week 3's own Section 10 entry actually names a W.1.x anchor at Week 3.
SS.6.W.1.4	Week 1	
SS.6.W.1.5	Weeks 10, 14, 17, 18	Herodotus as a primary source; distinguishing legendary from historical material.
SS.6.W.1.6	Week 16	Epic poetry as a vehicle for transmitting culture and models of character.

World History, Era 2 (SS.6.W.2.x, river-valley civilizations): 10 benchmarks.

Benchmark	Week(s) / Appendix	Note
SS.6.W.2.1	Week 1	
SS.6.W.2.2	Weeks 1, 2	Agriculture half at Week 1; metallurgy half at Week 2.
SS.6.W.2.3	Week 2	Characteristics of civilization.
SS.6.W.2.4	Weeks 5, 7, 8, 9	
SS.6.W.2.5	Weeks 5, 6, 10	
SS.6.W.2.6	Weeks 5, 6, 10	
SS.6.W.2.7	Weeks 2, 3, 4, 11, 12, 13, 17, 18	
SS.6.W.2.8	Weeks 3, 4, 11, 12, 13, 17, 18	
SS.6.W.2.9	Week 13 (primary); bridge at Week 11	Israelite beliefs and key figures; Jehu's tribute (Week 11) bridges to the full unit.
SS.6.W.2.10	Appendix	No Fall home (the Course Map's 18 weeks never reach the Americas). Satisfied

by the Appendices' Olmec Primary Source Exercise, calendar-fit noted for optional Friday enrichment alongside Week 7.

World History, Era 3 (SS.6.W.3.x, Greece/Rome/Kush/Axum): 18 benchmarks.

Benchmark	Week(s) / Appendix	Note
SS.6.W.3.1	Week 15	Direct, full fit: Phoenician cultural impact, Carthage's colonization, maritime commerce, the alphabet.
SS.6.W.3.2	Spring	Greek civilization proper.
SS.6.W.3.3	Spring	
SS.6.W.3.4	Spring	
SS.6.W.3.5	Spring	
SS.6.W.3.6	Week 16 (partial seed)	Via Homer; full ancient-Greek key-figures treatment is Spring.
SS.6.W.3.7	Spring	
SS.6.W.3.8	Spring	
SS.6.W.3.9	Spring	
SS.6.W.3.10	Spring	
SS.6.W.3.11	Spring	
SS.6.W.3.12	Spring	
SS.6.W.3.13	Spring	
SS.6.W.3.14	Spring	
SS.6.W.3.15	Spring	
SS.6.W.3.16	Spring	
SS.6.W.3.17	Spring	Roman civilization proper.
SS.6.W.3.18	Week 10	Kush's rise to power over Egypt only; Kush's fall, Axum, and Ethiopian Christianity

(partial) are Spring content, chronologically beyond this course's 525 BC endpoint.

World History, Era 4 (SS.6.W.4.x, India/China): 12 benchmarks.

Benchmark	Week(s) / Appendix	Note
SS.6.W.4.1	Spring/out of scope	
SS.6.W.4.2	Spring/out of scope	
SS.6.W.4.3	Spring/out of scope	
SS.6.W.4.4	Spring/out of scope	
SS.6.W.4.5	Spring/out of scope	
SS.6.W.4.6	Spring/out of scope	
SS.6.W.4.7	Spring/out of scope	
SS.6.W.4.8	Spring/out of scope	
SS.6.W.4.9	Week 7 (partial seed)	Via Fu Hao; full treatment is Spring.
SS.6.W.4.10	Spring/out of scope	
SS.6.W.4.11	Spring/out of scope	
SS.6.W.4.12	Spring/out of scope	

Cross-cutting: Mathematics Thinking & Reasoning, ELA Expectations, and ELD standards. Per CLAUDE .md, these are satisfied by design throughout the course rather than tagged lesson-by-lesson; the table below lists representative anchors only, not the full catalog, and no attempt is made here to force an artificial one-to-one lesson mapping for every MTR/EE/ELD code.

Standard	Representative anchor
MA.K12.MTR.1.1 (effortful learning), MTR.4.1 (discussion of reasoning)	Every Critical Questions set and Primary Source Exercise, by design.
MTR.6.1 (reasonableness of solutions)	Week 4's numeric law provisions; Week 14's eclipse-prediction reasoning.

ELA.K12.EE.1.1 (cite evidence)	Every Critical Questions set and Primary Source Exercise.
ELA.K12.EE.2.1 (grade-level complex texts)	Every Primary Source reading.
ELA.K12.EE.3.1 (inference)	Every Reading Quiz and Critical Questions set.
ELA.K12.EE.4.1 (collaborative discussion)	Every week's Discussion Topic.
ELA.K12.EE.5.1 (format rules)	Every Primary Source Report and Primary Source Exercise.
ELA.K12.EE.6.1 (voice and tone)	All student-facing writing.
ELD.K12.ELL.SI.1, ELD.K12.ELL.SS.1	The visual/graphic support built into every lesson (timelines, maps) and the discussion-topic structure.

The **A.4 Standards Crosswalk** Canvas Page in the Appendices module (student-visible, marked clearly as teacher reference) reproduces the tables above in full.

Section

10 Module-vs-week mapping, suggested pacing, and per-week entries

Module N = Week N, one to one, for all eighteen modules; there is no compression or multi-week module anywhere in this course. The course runs across two quarters (Weeks 1–9, then Weeks 10–18), each closed by its own Quarterly Exam. See the syllabi in the Teacher Module for this year's specific target dates; this manual does not repeat them, since a live teacher's own section may reasonably adjust pacing within a quarter.

Per-week entries below satisfy optima-world-history Part II's requirement that the manual "guide every lesson" with its standards benchmarks identified at the top of that entry. Each entry reformats, rather than re-derives, the standards paragraph already recorded in that week's own week-overview.md, plus that week's primary-source sourcing status from sourcing-log.md. All eighteen weeks. **Each week's standards paragraph was cross-checked directly against plan.md Section 2's master standards-coverage table rather than trusted on its own; three benchmarks that Weeks 14, 16, and 18 name in their own week-overview.md do not appear against those weeks in plan.md's table (SS.6.G.1.6 at Week 14, SS.6.W.1.3 at Week 16, SS.6.G.2.1 at Week 18). All three are carried below as the week file records them, and the discrepancy is logged plainly in Section 9 rather than silently resolved in either direction.**

Week 1: The Neolithic Revolution: Farming Begins Across the Ancient World

Standards: SS.6.W.1.2, SS.6.W.1.4, SS.6.W.2.1, SS.6.W.2.2 (agriculture half), SS.6.G.1.1, SS.6.G.2.3, SS.6.G.3.1, SS.6.G.4.3, SS.6.G.6.1, SS.6.E.1.3.

Primary sources: Kenyon's Jericho excavation report and Mellaart's Çatalhöyük excavation report are both presented as adapted classroom accounts, not verbatim quotation. Both are **flagged** in `sourcing-log.md`: both underlying publications are confirmed in-copyright 20th-century books, not available in open full text through the tools used during the re-sourcing pass. A follow-up session with library or Internet Archive lending access could pull genuine passages.

Week 2: Sumer and the Rise of the First Cities

Standards: SS.6.W.2.2 (metallurgy half), SS.6.W.2.3, SS.6.W.2.7, SS.6.G.1.6, SS.6.G.2.3, SS.6.G.2.7, SS.6.E.2.1.

Primary sources: the Sumerian King List is **sourced** (Electronic Text Corpus of Sumerian Literature, Oxford, CC BY-NC-SA). The Epic of Gilgamesh Flood Tablet is **flagged, partial**: R. Campbell Thompson's 1928 public-domain translation is confirmed to exist, but the hosts carrying its full text blocked automated retrieval during the re-sourcing pass; real fragments were recovered via search and used to keep wording aligned with Thompson's actual choices.

Week 3: Sargon and the World's First Empire: The Akkadians

Standards: SS.6.W.2.7, SS.6.W.2.8, SS.6.E.3.2 (seed; full spotlight Week 6), ELA.K12.EE.3.1.

Primary sources: the Legend of Sargon (Birth Legend) and the Curse of Akkad are both **sourced** (Electronic Text Corpus of Sumerian Literature, Oxford, cross-checked against Pritchard's *Ancient Near Eastern Texts* for the Sargon legend).

Week 4: Hammurabi and Old Babylon: Law and Kingship in Mesopotamia

Standards: SS.6.W.2.7, SS.6.W.2.8, SS.6.CG.1.3 (partial), SS.6.E.1.3, SS.6.G.2.1, SS.6.G.4.2.

Primary sources: both the selected laws and the Prologue of the Code of Hammurabi are **sourced and verified** against L.W. King's 1915 public-domain translation, hosted by the Avalon Project (Yale Law School), directly fetched and confirmed verbatim.

Sensitive content: Lesson 2 discusses the Code's differential legal treatment of free citizens, commoners, and slaves. See Section 14.

Week 5: The Gift of the Nile: Predynastic Egypt and the Old Kingdom

Standards: SS.6.W.2.4, SS.6.W.2.5, SS.6.W.2.6, SS.6.G.1.3, SS.6.G.1.6, SS.6.G.2.3, SS.6.G.2.1.

Primary sources: the Narmer Palette is **sourced, structural** (the object genuinely carries only short name-labels, not continuous text; the lesson's register-by-register description is an honest representation, not a gap). The Instructions of Ptahhotep is **sourced and verified** against Battiscombe Gunn's 1906 translation, confirmed at Project Gutenberg.

Week 6: Pharaohs and Empire: Middle and New Kingdom Egypt *(graded VR Activity)*

Standards: SS.6.W.2.5, SS.6.W.2.6, SS.6.E.3.2, SS.6.G.5.1, SS.6.G.2.5.

Primary sources: Hatshepsut's Punt Inscription and the Annals of Thutmose III (Battle of Megiddo) are both **sourced** (James Henry Breasted, *Ancient Records of Egypt*, Vol. II, 1906, public domain; the Megiddo annals cross-referenced with Budge).

Week 7: Beyond Mesopotamia and Egypt: The Indus Valley and Shang China *(graded VR Activity)*

Standards: SS.6.W.2.4, SS.6.G.2.2, SS.6.G.2.6, SS.6.G.4.3, SS.6.W.4.9 (partial seed; full treatment a future semester).

Primary sources: Marshall's Mohenjo-daro Excavation Report is **flagged, partial**: a full-text digital copy exists at the Internet Archive but its content could not be extracted through the tools available during the re-sourcing pass. The Shang Oracle Bone Inscriptions are **sourced, representative**: genre and content confirmed against Keightley's standard scholarly reference, though exact page-level wording was not extracted.

Week 8: Palaces and Powers: Minoan Crete, Mycenaean Greece, and the Hittite Empire *(graded VR Activity)*

Standards: SS.6.W.2.4, SS.6.G.2.4, SS.6.G.2.1, SS.6.E.2.1.

Primary sources: the Egyptian-Hittite Peace Treaty is **sourced** (D.D. Luckenbill's 1921 translation of the Akkadian version, cross-referenced with Breasted's translation of the Egyptian version). Homer's *Iliad* Catalogue of Ships is **sourced and verified, partial**: Samuel Butler's 1898 translation confirmed in full at Wikisource; the invocation and the Boeotian entry are verbatim, the remaining four entries are close paraphrase pending a further verbatim check.

Week 9: The Bronze Age Collapse: Ancient Near East in Crisis (*closes Quarter 1*)

Standards: SS.6.W.2.4, SS.6.G.3.2, SS.6.G.5.3.

Primary sources: Ramesses III's Medinet Habu Inscription is **sourced** (Breasted, *Ancient Records of Egypt*, Vol. IV). The Pylos "Rower Tablets" are **sourced, representative fragment**: the genuine tablets are terse administrative lists, so the lesson's fuller sentences are a structurally honest adaptation, with specific officer names flagged for a follow-up check against Chadwick's *Documents in Mycenaean Greek*.

Week 10: Twilight of the Pharaohs: Egypt's Third Intermediate Period and the Saite Revival (*opens Quarter 2*)

Standards: SS.6.W.2.5, SS.6.W.2.6 (Piye and the Kushite Twenty-fifth Dynasty as Egyptian achievements and key figures), SS.6.W.1.3, SS.6.W.1.5 (Herodotus as a primary source; distinguishing legendary material from plausible eyewitness reporting), SS.6.W.3.18 (partial: Kush's rise to power over Egypt only; Kush's later fall, Axum, and Ethiopian Christianity are Spring content), SS.6.E.3.3 (partial: Egypt and Kush's traditional economy only; Greece and Rome are Spring content), SS.6.G.2.6 (cultural diffusion: Kush's adoption of Egyptian religious and written tradition).

Primary sources: the Great Triumphal Stele of Piye is **sourced** (James Henry Breasted, *Ancient Records of Egypt*, Part IV, 1906, Sections 816ff, public domain, verbatim via attalus.org's hosted transcription). Herodotus, *Histories* Book II (on Egypt) is **sourced** (G.C. Macaulay's 1890 translation, public domain, verbatim via Project Gutenberg).

Week 11: Assyria Fills the Vacuum: The Rise of the Neo-Assyrian Empire

Standards: SS.6.W.2.7, SS.6.W.2.8 (Neo-Assyrian imperial administration and expansion), SS.6.G.5.2 (Assyrian road and communication networks supporting a large, expanding empire), SS.6.G.2.4 (movement and diffusion of Assyrian military technology and administrative practice), SS.6.W.2.9 (bridge only this week, via Jehu of Israel's tribute; full Israelite treatment in Week 13).

Primary sources: Ashurnasirpal II's Annals is **sourced** (D.D. Luckenbill, *Ancient Records of Assyria and Babylonia*, Vol. I, 1926, public domain; the flaying/impaling passages are confirmed verbatim via cross-referenced secondary quotation of Luckenbill's translation; one feast-attendance figure is one step removed from its primary publication, flagged for a follow-up direct check against Pritchard or Luckenbill's own rendering). The Black Obelisk of Shalmaneser III is **sourced, structural** (the same short-epigraph genre as the Narmer Palette, Week 5; Luckenbill, Section 590, cross-checked against a second independent rendering of the same short text).

Sensitive content: Lesson 1 presents Ashurnasirpal II's own recorded use of flaying, impaling, and skull-towers built from the defeated as calculated, publicized state policy. See Section 14.

Week 12: Nineveh and Ashurbanipal: The Assyrian Empire at Its Height and Its Fall (graded VR Activity)

Standards: SS.6.W.2.7, SS.6.W.2.8 (the Neo-Assyrian Empire at its height and its collapse), SS.6.W.1.3 (Ashurbanipal's library tablets and the Babylonian Chronicle as primary sources, including how physical preservation shapes what evidence survives), SS.6.G.2.1 (human systems: royal library administration and the diffusion of scholarly texts across the empire).

Primary sources: Ashurbanipal's Library Tablets is **sourced, partial**: a genuine education/scribal-training inscription (high confidence via cross-referenced quotations tied to the open-access RINAP 5 project, though not confirmed word-for-word against the primary publication itself this pass) and a genuine library colophon curse (confirmed via the Oriental Institute's Ashurbanipal Library Project); flagged for a follow-up direct check against Luckenbill's *Ancient Records of Assyria and Babylonia*, Vol. II, or the RINAP 5 volume. The Babylonian Chronicle (Fall of Nineveh, 612 BC) is **sourced, partial** (C.J. Gadd, 1923, public domain, hosted in full at the Internet Archive; the summary-table phrasing is confirmed verbatim, but Gadd's full page-37 line-by-line translation could not be extracted this pass, flagged for a follow-up session with the archive.org page-image reader).

Week 13: Nebuchadnezzar's Babylon: The Neo-Babylonian Empire and the Fall of Jerusalem

Standards: SS.6.W.2.9 (primary standard this week: Israelite monotheism and covenant theology, presented as a genuine comparison of religious commitments rather than a flattened equivalence), SS.6.W.2.7, SS.6.W.2.8 (Neo-Babylonian imperial administration and expansion under Nebuchadnezzar II), SS.6.G.4.4 (the spread and persistence of belief systems, especially through exile), SS.6.G.4.2 (the Babylonian exile as a case of forced migration), SS.6.CG.1.3 (further partial bridge: Mosaic law and covenant tradition as another rule-of-law origin named in the standard's own clarification; full Greek and Roman treatment remains Spring content).

Primary sources: the Babylonian Chronicles (Siege of Jerusalem, 597 BC) is **sourced, in-copyright minimal fair-use quotation** (D.J. Wiseman, *Chronicles of Chaldaean Kings*, British Museum, 1956, the tablet's first-ever publication; no earlier public-domain translation exists because the tablet itself was unknown before 1956; the short chronicle entry is quoted directly, confirmed consistent across multiple independent scholarly citations of Wiseman's translation). Nebuchadnezzar II's Building Inscriptions (Ishtar Gate) is **sourced** (Stephen Langdon, 1912, public domain, cross-checked against the modern open-access Royal Inscriptions of the Neo-Babylonian Empire project, LMU Munich).

Sensitive content: Lesson 2 covers Assyria's mass deportation of the northern kingdom of Israel (722 BC) and Babylon's destruction of Jerusalem and its Temple, followed by the exile of Judah's population (586 BC). See Section 14.

Week 14: The Medes: Six Centuries in the Shadows of the Zagros Mountains

Standards: SS.6.W.1.5 (Herodotus as a source, and distinguishing legendary from historical figures, applied here to Deioces), SS.6.G.2.5 (Median territorial expansion and shifting regional power), SS.6.G.1.6 (Zagros Mountains as a defining physical-geographic feature), SS.6.G.4.1 (Median tribal and family-based social organization prior to unification), SS.6.G.1.5 (map and distance work plotting Media's rise from the Zagros Mountains to the Halys River border).

Primary sources: both Herodotus, *Histories* Book I (on Deioces and the Founding of Media) and Herodotus's Account of the Battle of the Eclipse (585 BC) are **sourced**: the Deioces material via George Rawlinson's 1858–1860 translation (public domain, verbatim via a hosted transcription); the Eclipse material via G.C. Macaulay's 1890 translation (public domain, verbatim via Project Gutenberg), cross-checked against Rawlinson's rendering of the same episode for consistency.

Standards note: SS.6.G.1.6 is named for this week in Week 14's own week-overview.md but does not appear against Week 14 in plan.md Section 2's master table (which lists G.1.6 only at Weeks 2, 5, and 15). Carried here as the week file records it; see Section 9.

Week 15: Phoenicia in the Mediterranean: Carthage Faces Rome (*graded VR Activity*)

Standards: SS.6.W.3.1 (primary standard this week: Phoenician cultural impact, Carthage's colonization, maritime commerce, and the alphabet), SS.6.E.3.1, SS.6.E.3.4 (Phoenician trade relationships and traded goods), SS.6.E.3.2 (traded goods and barriers to trade, direct continuation from Weeks 3 and 6), SS.6.E.1.1 (factors of economic growth applied to Phoenician shipbuilding and dye production), SS.6.G.2.5 (cultural diffusion through colonization), SS.6.G.5.2 (transportation and trade networks across the Mediterranean).

Primary sources: the Legendary Founding of Carthage (Dido, per Virgil and Justin) is **sourced, partial** (John Selby Watson's 1853 translation of Justin's *Epitome*, Book 18, and John Dryden's 1697 translation of Virgil's *Aeneid*, both public domain and both verbatim-confirmed for their quoted passages; the opening sentence of Justin's own account, Pygmalion's murder of Acerbas, is accurate in content via secondary scholarly citation but was not retrieved word-for-word this pass, flagged for a follow-up direct check). The Legendary Founding of Rome (Romulus and Remus, per Livy) is **sourced** (Rev. Canon Roberts's 1912 translation, public domain, verbatim via Project Gutenberg).

Week 16: The Greek Dark Ages: Homer and a New Beginning for Greece

Standards: SS.6.W.1.6 (this course's fullest treatment: history and epic poetry as a vehicle for transmitting culture and models of human character, through Achilles and Odysseus), SS.6.W.1.3 (oral tradition as a distinct kind of historical source, with its own strengths and distortions), SS.6.W.3.6 (partial seed: Homer as a foundational figure of Greek civilization; full ancient-Greek key-figures treatment reserved for Spring), SS.6.G.2.6 (the alphabet's adoption from Phoenician script, c. 800 BC, as cultural diffusion, the direct payoff of Week 15).

Primary sources: both Homer's *Iliad*, Book 1 (Quarrel of Achilles and Agamemnon) and Homer's *Odyssey*, Book 9 (Odysseus and the Cyclops) are **sourced and verified** (Samuel Butler's 1898 prose translation, public domain, confirmed in full at Wikisource; both quoted verbatim, matching the same translation and translator already established for Week 8).

Standards note: SS.6.W.1.3 is named for this week in Week 16's own week-overview.md but does not appear against Week 16 in p1an.md Section 2's master table (which names only SS.6.W.1.6 as Week 16's cross-cutting anchor). Carried here as the week file records it; see Section 9. (The earlier Section 9 stub's claim that Era 1 anchors fall "explicitly at Weeks 1 and 3" was itself unconfirmed against either p1an.md's actual anchor list or Week 3's own entry above, and is superseded by the corrected list in Section 9.)

Week 17: Cyrus the Great: Mesopotamia Under Persian Rule

Standards: SS.6.W.2.7, SS.6.W.2.8 (the rise of the Achaemenid Persian Empire and its administration), SS.6.W.1.5 (Herodotus as a source, and distinguishing legendary from historical material in Cyrus's own origin story), SS.6.G.2.6 (Persian imperial expansion as a new, larger scale of cultural and political diffusion), SS.6.E.3.4 (trade relationships across a newly unified, multi-ethnic empire).

Primary sources: the Cyrus Cylinder is **sourced, in-copyright minimal fair-use quotation** (no public-domain translation of this text exists at all; quotations follow Mordechai Cogan's translation as adapted for Livius.org, based on H. Schaudig's critical edition, cross-checked against the British Museum's own modern translation). Herodotus, *Histories* Book I (on Cyrus's Rise and the Fall of Croesus of Lydia) is **sourced and verified** (George Rawlinson's translation for Astyages's dream and Cyrus's infancy; G.C. Macaulay's translation for Solon's visit to Croesus; both quoted verbatim).

Week 18: Cambyses II Conquers Egypt: Persian Empire Unites the Ancient World (*graded VR Activity; closes Quarter 2 and the Fall Semester's 18-week build*)

Standards: SS.6.W.2.7, SS.6.W.2.8 (the Achaemenid Empire's culmination in a single Near Eastern empire spanning Mesopotamia, Egypt, and Persia), SS.6.W.1.3 (the Behistun Inscription's unique role as a primary source that made other primary sources readable), SS.6.W.1.5 (Herodotus as a source, extended here to a hostile source with a plausible motive, not just legend versus history), SS.6.G.1.7, SS.6.G.1.2 (capstone map work plotting the full Achaemenid Empire's extent across three river valleys), SS.6.G.2.1 (Persian administrative reach across a newly unified empire).

Primary sources: Herodotus, *Histories* Book III (on Cambyses's Conquest of Egypt at Pelusium) is **sourced, partial** (George Rawlinson's translation, cross-checked against Macaulay's rendering of the same passage; the Apis-bull incident is quoted verbatim; the Pelusium battle narrative and the "openly deranged" characterization were not re-confirmed verbatim this pass and were dropped from the primary-source excerpt rather than left as invented prose). The Behistun Inscription (Darius I) is **sourced** (L.W. King and R.C. Thompson, 1907, public domain, verbatim via Wikisource's full hosted text; note this translation renders the usurper's claimed identity as "Smerdis" rather than "Bardiya," the same figure under its Greek versus Old Persian name, flagged for a consistency check against the lesson file).

Standards note: SS.6.G.2.1 is named for this week in Week 18's own week-overview.md but does not appear against Week 18 in plan.md Section 2's master table (which lists G.2.1 only at Weeks 1, 5, 8, and 12). Carried here as the week file records it; see Section 9. The Fall Semester review lesson and cumulative final assessment are their own separate build stage and are not part of this Week 18 entry.

Section

Vocabulary and reading-level conventions

Every lesson targets 800–1,200 words (1,000 the sweet spot) and a glossary window of exactly two lessons: the lesson where a term first appears, and the immediately following lesson only, even if the word recurs later in the course. Subject-vocabulary terms get a boxed definition with phonetic spelling and audio playback at the top of the lesson; foreign-language terms and every historical figure's name get a separate box placed inline near their first use, English gloss bolded and the foreign term italicized in parentheses, also with audio. Unlike some other Optima courses, **every one of this course's 36 lessons** is GitHub-hosted with real hover/audio glossing wired via the browser's built-in text-to-speech; there is no plain-Canvas-page subset that only carries phonetic spelling without audio.

Reading level, stated honestly, by quarter. All 36 lessons were rewritten to land in the 800–1,200 word band, and reading level improved substantially through multiple simplification passes, but it does not land uniformly at the school's 6th-grade target: Weeks 1–4 settled at roughly grade 7–9 (word counts 823–891); Weeks 5–9 at roughly grade 8–9.6 (word counts 886–989); Weeks 10–14 at roughly grade 8–8.7 (word counts 882–1,006); Weeks 15–18 at roughly grade 7.8–9 (word counts 803–934). This gap is a documented, accepted limitation driven by the density of required proper nouns and historical vocabulary at this content level (Mesopotamia, Ashurbanipal, sexagesimal, contingency), not an oversight. Do not represent this course's lessons as uniformly 6th-grade reading level to a family or administrator who asks; do not attempt to close the remaining gap by cutting or avoiding required vocabulary.

Section

12 Documented, accepted exceptions

These are deliberate decisions, made and recorded by the course lead, not oversights. Do not "fix" any of them without revisiting the underlying decision first.

- **Tier 3 carries roughly 49% of graded items (44 of 90), well above the general 10–15% target.** Every week's Critical Questions and Primary Source Exercise are both genuinely reasoning-quality-graded work, so both were placed in Tier 3 rather than splitting one off into a lighter tier. Explicitly accepted by the course lead; do not re-propose splitting them.
- **Quarterly Exams sit in their own dedicated top-level assignment group (30%),** against optima-mj-social-studies' general instruction to fold them into an existing group. Made because no combination of point values inside an existing group could cleanly produce a real 30% outcome. See Section 7.
- **The M365/MOS digital-skills surface is limited to one file-producing deliverable,** the Course Review's Tier 3 comparative essay. Widening it (for example, converting the 6 graded VR Activities to `.docx` submissions) was costed, offered, and explicitly declined by the course lead, on the grounds that MOS Core coverage is a cross-course, grades 6–8 curriculum question, not one to solve inside a single course. Do not re-propose without new information.
- **The Course Review (end of Week 18) is optional and marked omit_from_final_grade.** Middle school reports quarter and course grades, not a required cumulative exam, so the review's three graded-shaped parts (a Tier 1 quiz, a Tier 2 discussion, a Tier 3 essay) carry points but do not count toward the grade. Students may still complete them for feedback.
- **16 of 18 Lesson 2 pages carry no Main Map of their own** (confirmed by direct count: only Week 1 and Week 13 give Lesson 2 its own Main Map; every other week's Lesson 2 relies on the map already given in that week's Lesson 1). This is a real, confirmed gap in this course's build, not hidden here: a teacher relying on the geography callouts should know Lesson 2 pages other than Weeks 1 and 13 do not carry a fresh map of their own. Map work on this course is frozen; this is logged, not scheduled for a fix.
- **4 of the 36 primary sources are flagged as unlocatable in verbatim form** (Kenyon's Jericho report and Mellaart's Çatalhöyük report, both Week 1; the Gilgamesh Flood Tablet, Week 2, partial; Marshall's Mohenjo-daro report, Week 7, partial), each with a real, cited publication identified but not obtained through the tools used during the re-sourcing pass, and each flagged in its own lesson file. Two further sources (the Siege of Jerusalem Chronicle, Week 13; the Cyrus Cylinder, Week 17) are sourced only via minimal, precisely cited quotation of an in-copyright text with no free public-domain alternative at all, a related but distinct limitation, not a further "unlocatable" flag. *Note: an earlier planning note put this count at 5 flagged sources; a direct recount against sourcing-log.md confirms 4 carry the literal*

FLAGGED status. Corrected here.

- **30 supplemental VR Activities are unpublished at 0 points in Tier 4**, publishable at any teacher's discretion. This is the intended delivered state, not an incomplete build.

Section

What makes this course classical

- **Contingency first.** Every week surfaces at least one moment where history could plausibly have gone otherwise, most explicitly Sargon's improbable rise (Week 3), the still-contested causes of the Bronze Age Collapse (Week 9), and the Battle of the Eclipse halting a war outright (Week 14). The Critical Questions rotation's counterfactual slot exists specifically for this.
- **Great Men and Great Events as the narrative spine.** Sargon, Hammurabi, Hatshepsut, Thutmose III, Ashurbanipal, Nebuchadnezzar II, and Cyrus are named and evaluated directly, never routed to a sidebar to avoid their names, per the course's explicit rejection of that carve-out (that pattern is Civics-only, not this course).
- **Classical Republican evaluation.** Regimes and civic cultures are judged by whether their laws, customs, and habits solve first-order political and economic problems, most sharply in the direct comparison this course draws between Assyrian terror (Weeks 11–12) and Persian tolerance (Week 17) as two different answers to the same problem: how does a large empire bind a diverse population together.
- **Primary sources, every week.** Students meet Hammurabi's Code, Herodotus, the Cyrus Cylinder, and Homer directly, not a textbook's summary of them, and where a source cannot be verified verbatim this manual and the lesson itself say so plainly rather than passing off invented prose as authentic.
- **Anti-Whiggish, non-teleological history throughout.** The Bronze Age Collapse (Week 9) is the course's explicit paradigm case: multiple great powers fail within decades for reasons still genuinely contested, resisting any single tidy explanation or claim of inevitable progress.

Section

14 Sensitive-content flags & family/student scripts

Flag these in advance. Give a neutral setup; save any debate for the lesson. These three are confirmed by direct reading of the lesson files, not assumed from the topic list alone.

Where	What
Week 4, Lesson 2	The Code of Hammurabi's differential legal treatment of free citizens (<i>amelu</i>), commoners (<i>mushkenum</i>), and slaves, who held the legal status of property rather than full personhood under the Code. The lesson names this plainly rather than smoothing it over, alongside the Code's real, if limited, protections.
Week 11, Lesson 1	Ashurnasirpal II's use of publicized, deliberate violence (flaying rebels alive, impaling captives, towers built from the skulls of the defeated) as calculated state policy, openly recorded by the king himself rather than hidden. The lesson presents this directly, as a case study in terror as a tool of imperial control, not for shock value.
Week 13, Lesson 2	Assyria's mass deportation of the northern kingdom of Israel (722 BC) and Babylon's destruction of Jerusalem and its Temple, followed by the exile of Judah's population (586 BC).

"Dear families, in the coming weeks our class reads primary sources dealing with [the unequal legal treatment of enslaved people under ancient Mesopotamian law / a Neo-Assyrian king's own recorded use of violence as a tool of imperial control / the conquest, deportation, and exile of ancient Israelite and Judahite populations]. We approach this material soberly and historically, using the actual sources rather than a summary, because understanding how this era actually unfolded is central to World History. If you'd like to talk through the material or have questions, please reach out, [name], [email], office hours [day/time]."

Section

15 Running this course live

The course is written once and runs in two sections from the same content: Live (synchronous) and On-Demand (asynchronous). Both syllabi live in the Teacher Module (Section 0 above) and differ only in section logistics, not academic content.

Live (synchronous)

On-Demand (asynchronous)

You're called	Teacher	Facilitator
Pacing	Scheduled class meetings	Self-paced within each quarter, guided by due dates
Attendance measured by	Presence and participation; notify in advance of an absence	Assignment completion

Turning the weekly segment list into a live rhythm. Nothing in the built course prescribes a fixed number of live meetings per week, so use the module's own segment order (Section 1) as your seminar plan: open with the Intro Wrapper's essential question as a live warm-up; teach Lesson 1 and hold the Primary Source 1 reading as a group seminar, using the Critical Questions prompts as your discussion spine; teach Lesson 2 and, on weeks that carry one, run the required VR Activity as a shared session followed by a short gallery walk; and close by having students draft the Primary Source Exercise in class, where you can coach in real time, before the Outro Wrapper. On Discussion weeks (2, 4, 9, 11, 13, 16), the Discussion Topic doubles well as a live seminar's spine, then students post the same claim-and-response in Canvas afterward. The Reading Quiz works well as a live warm-up or exit ticket either way, same auto-grading, but it now also tells you what to reteach before the next seminar.

MJ World History: Dawn of Civilization to Roman Empire · Florida 2109010 · Facilitator Manual, Optima Academy Online, 2026–2027.
 Synthesized from the built Canvas course (course 104; 18 weekly modules, Weeks 1–18; Reading Quizzes, Critical Questions, Primary Source Exercises, 6 Discussions, 36 VR Activities, two Quarterly MC Exams, and Module Intro/Outro wrappers) and verified against the live course via the Canvas API. Complete across two authoring sessions (2026-08-03, 2026-08-04). Facilitator copy, not for student distribution.